21. This approximate regional span is taken from Cahen et al., "Ghuzz", *EI*² (2012). These authors admittedly concentrated on the *western* Oghüz and other Turkic groups, as these were mentioned in Arabic- and Persian-language texts, often through first-hand accounts of the merchants and proselytizers encountering them (see Chapter 2). The Oghüz's eastern brethren, the Toküz–Oghüz, remained more remote and lesser known.
22. Nazim (1933: 610–614, trans. 622–628) first published Sabuktigin's putatively autobiographical *Pand-nama*, which was to be found only as copied in a fourteenth-century text. It briefly mentioned Sabuktigin's boyhood among the Turkic Barskhan clan, his abduction and sale at the slave market of Nakhshab (modern Qarshi in Uzbekistan), and ultimately the Samanid *ghulam* Alptigin's purchase of him in Bukhara. Sabuktigin described the worship of stone idols among some Turkic tribes and his own skepticism of the practice, indicating his pre-destined conversion to Islam. Sabuktigin's origins also included the historiographically requisite Sasanian connections, cf. Bosworth 1973: 61. See also Barthold 1968: 261–262. Such a biographical trajectory was common among the slaves who rose to the status of *ghulam*s, as also indicated by the parallel story of Qutb al-Din Aibek – cf. Juzjani, vol. I, 1963: 415–416 (trans. vol. I, 1881: 512–514).
23. See, e.g., Wilkinson 2016: 3. A caveat is required here: satellite data usually collected for US and other super-power intelligence agencies have concentrated on more populated areas, "river valleys and along roads, leaving blank spaces especially in mountain and desert areas" (cf. Hammer et al. 2017: 5). Thus, at times even this otherwise invaluable resource can inadvertently reinforce historical *lacunae* in knowledge rather than remedy them. Nevertheless, the areas whence satellite data have recently been analyzed include the northern arc of Balkh and the Balkhab River, as well as the historically less explored southern reaches of Afghanistan around the Helmand River and Sistan. Satellite images of the latter, for example, have revealed at least 119 caravanserais built approximately every 20 km. Dated to the late sixteenth–early seventeenth centuries and considered to be part of a "centrally sponsored effort," these way-stations connected the Safavid (1501–1732) and Mughal (1525–1858) realms in uninterrupted trade and travel routes, altering the view that the Safavid empire had entered a politico-economic decline by this period. Cf. Lawler 2017: 1364; Franklin and Boak 2019. For a recent study on hydrological development and change in the Balkh oasis during the ninth–thirteenth centuries – based on satellite data, in large part – see Wordsworth 2018. Other satellite data have reconfirmed earlier archaeological work in regions such as the vicinity of Qandahar, where ceramic finds imported from Safavid Iran were the most substantive corpus unearthed by excavations (Crowe 1996: 314, 320). Provided all dating is accurate, these rediscoveries underscore the centrality of Afghanistan for the Indic and Iranian cultural worlds during the early modern period. See esp. Chapter 4 for the use of Google Earth and other satellite imagery toward the apprehension of historical data not previously gleaned from architectural complexes and their surrounding landscapes.
24. A perfect case in point would be the mid-twentieth century's strict division of intellectual labor among disciplines, amply demonstrated in works